



Lewisham College research ethics approval proposal

Title: The Effects of Uniform Colour on School Students' Personal Relationships

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Introduction

Uniforms in educational institutions serve multiple purposes, including fostering a sense of belonging, promoting equality, and minimising distractions. However, there is limited research on the potential influence of uniform colour segregation on students' personal relationships within the school environment and how this may impact on their academic performance. In this context, this study aims to investigate the effects of wearing different coloured uniforms on the interpersonal dynamics of school students and the impact on their learning.

Research Objectives

Understanding how uniform colour impacts personal relationships can have significant implications for educational institutions and policymakers. It may shed light on potential strategies to enhance social cohesion, inclusivity, and overall student wellbeing. In this context the primary objectives of this research are as follows:

1. To examine if wearing different coloured uniforms influences students' social interactions.
2. To assess whether uniform colour affects students' perceptions of belonging and inclusion.
3. To identify any potential psychological or emotional effects associated with uniform colour variations.
4. To examine if learning outcomes are affected by segregation based on different colour uniforms.

Research Questions

The research will address the following questions:

1. How does wearing a different coloured uniform influence students' social interactions at school?
2. Are there differences in students' perceptions of belonging and inclusion based on uniform colour?
3. What are the potential psychological and emotional effects associated with uniform colour variations?
4. How are student learning outcomes affected by segregation based on different colour uniforms?

Research Methodology

Participants

The study will involve a diverse sample of my students from Catford Boys School across various grade levels. Efforts will be made to include a balanced representation of students from different ethnicities, and socioeconomic backgrounds.

Experimental Design

Participants will be selected from my classes and assigned a different colour (brown) uniform, which is different from the black standard uniform. Specifically, groups of friends will be divided through imposing one friend to wear the brown uniform and allowing the other to continue wearing the black uniform. Students wearing the brown uniform (30) will be the experimental group while students wearing the black uniform (30) will be the control group.

Data Collection Methods

Participants will complete pre- and post-intervention surveys to assess social interactions, perceptions of belonging, and emotional well-being. Also, students' grades will be assessed before and after the experiment to determine if the uniform changes have had positive or negative effects on the students' education. I will also observe, record, and analyse social interactions during designated periods (e.g., lunch breaks, recess). The aim is to determine if student friendships are positively or negatively affected through the uniform changes.

Duration

The study will span 6 weeks to allow for adequate data collection and potential adjustments in student behaviour.

Data Analysis

Quantitative data will be analysed using appropriate statistical techniques.

Research Ethics

This study will prioritise ethical standards by ensuring anonymity, and confidentiality throughout the data collection phase of the study. To this end students will be assigned an alias and in the published article only the school's name will be mentioned without reference to the students' specific years of study. Regarding consent, it is essential not to alert the students to the nature of the experiment as this may affect their behaviour and thus render any findings inaccurate. Rather students will be told the change of uniform colour is a new school policy, which must be adhered to, and after the completion of the data collection phase the parents/guardians will be provided with detailed information about the study.

Significance of the Study and expected findings

Understanding the effects of uniform colour on personal relationships in school can provide valuable insights for educators, administrators, and policymakers. The findings may lead to recommendations for optimising uniform policies to promote a more inclusive and harmonious learning environment. To this end, it is hypothesised that students in the experimental group will be stigmatised by the students in the control group and consequently lose friendships with students in the control group. However, at the same time it is expected that new friendships will be formed in the experimental group. Regarding their academic performance, it is expected that the trauma from the initial stigmatisation will cause the experimental group's academic performance to decline, while it is not expected the control group will be affected.